

Back Off and Give Up

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Acknowledgement of Country

Hayward (in San Francisco Bay Area)
Ancestral homeland of the Ohlone people

The Secret to Resilient Systems

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Quit

Naive Retries

The problem

Naive Retry: The Classic Mistake

```
import time
import requests

def get_data(url):
    while True:
        try:
            response = requests.get(url, timeout=5)
            return response.json()
        except requests.RequestException:
            time.sleep(1)
```

Thundering Herd

Thundering Herd

Recover

Thundering Herd

Recover
Crash

Retry Storms

Frontend → API Gateway → Payment Service

Retry Storms

Frontend → API Gateway → Payment Service

3

Retry Storms

Frontend → API Gateway → Payment Service

3

×3

Retry Storms

Frontend → API Gateway → Payment Service

3

×3

= 27

Retry Storms

Frontend → API Gateway → Payment Service

3

×3

= 27

$27 \times 100 = 2,700$

Back-off

Do better!

Exponential

Wait

Exponential

Wait

Proportional to outage

Basic Implementation

```
wait_time = 2 ** attempt  
time.sleep(wait_time)
```

Jitter

Without jitter:

Jitter

Without jitter: Everyone at $T=4s$

A Tale of Two Worlds: Premise

Recipe recommendation site with ML backend

A Tale of Two Worlds: World 1

Max backoff = 1 second

A Tale of Two Worlds: World 2

Max backoff = 10 minutes

Tenacity

```
@retry(  
    stop=stop_after_attempt(5),  
    wait=wait_exponential(  
        max=300 # 5 minutes!  
    )  
)
```


Giving Up

Tactical retreat

Why Give Up?

Avoid catastrophizing

Circuit Breaker

Three states:

Circuit Breaker

Three states:
Closed

Circuit Breaker

Three states:

Closed

Open

Circuit Breaker

Three states:

Closed

Open

Half-Open

PyBreaker

```
@CircuitBreaker(  
    fail_max=5,  
    reset_timeout=60  
)  
def get_user_data(user_id):  
    return database.query(...)
```

Load Shedding

Priority levels

Optional Features

```
@optional_feature(fallback=[])  
def get_recommendations(user_id):  
    return ml_model.predict(user_id)
```

Putting It Together

Configuration time

Real Configuration

```
retry:  
  max_delay: 300  # 5 minutes!  
  jitter: true
```

```
circuit_breaker:  
  failure_threshold: 5  
  recovery_timeout: 60
```

```
load_shedding:  
  0.7: ["reports"]  
  0.8: ["recommendations"]  
  0.9: ["non_critical"]
```

Monitor Everything

Monitor Everything

Metrics

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Metrics

Alerts

Key Takeaways

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- ▶ Exponential backoff with jitter
- ▶ Max backoff: 1-10 minutes
- ▶ Give up
- ▶ Prioritize

Resources

Libraries:

- ▶ `tenacity`
- ▶ `pybreaker`

Questions?

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